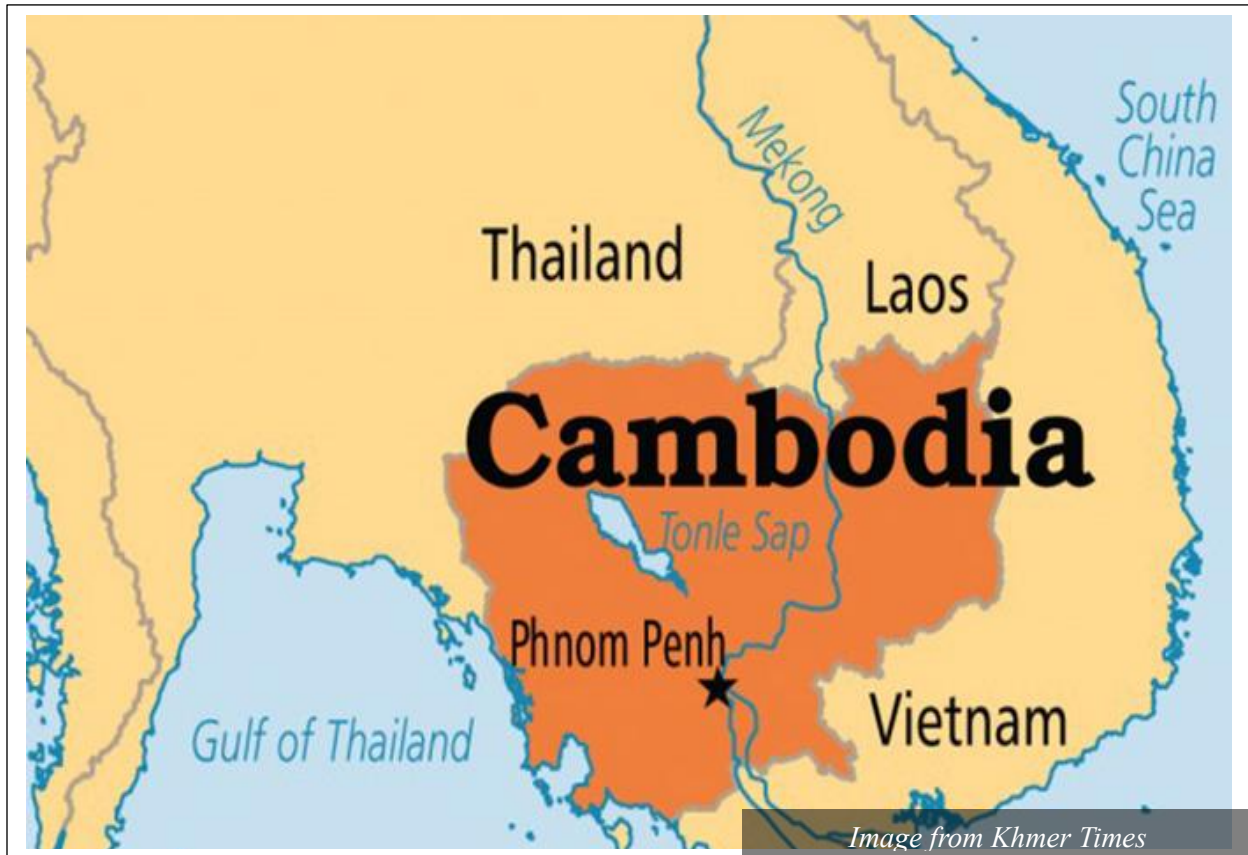




The Centrifugal Turn: Navigating the New Global Order and Cambodia's Strategic Agency

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Author: Dr. Sayumphu Ros
Research Fellow, China-ASEAN Studies Center

The international system in 2026 has moved far beyond the stable expectations of the late 20th century. The Liberal International Order (LIO) that structured global relations since the end of World War II has entered a state of "deep contestation," where its fundamental norms are no longer universally shared and its core architects face internal fractures (Lake, 2026). We have transitioned from a "centripetal era" (1980–2010), defined by economic coalescence and geopolitical alignment, into a "centrifugal era" (2011–present) marked by fragmentation, trade wars, and the rise of a multipolar distribution of power (Ing & Rodrik, 2026; Quah, 2026). For small states, this shift is existential. Nowhere is this dynamic more visible than in the strategic partnership between Cambodia and China, a relationship that serves as an example of how small-state agency and superpower strategy converge in a world where trust in old systems has eroded.

The New World Order: Patterns of Fragmentation

The current world order is increasingly defined by a "transactional approach" to international relations. The United States, once the primary guarantor of global rules, has moved toward a more "nationalist, unilateralist, and sovereigntist" stance (Lake, 2026). This shift has effectively sidelined traditional multilateral consensus, replacing it with "forceful coercion to open domestic markets" and a reliance on bilateral deals rather than universal standards (Maltsev, 2026).

For small states, the primary issue is the loss of growth opportunities as "provide-all" multilateralism is replaced by competing spheres of influence (Urata, 2026). States are increasingly forced to navigate a system where supply chains are clustered around trusted partners rather than universal rules (Lake, 2026). This centrifugal force is fueled by the "China shock," the perception, primarily in the United States and the West, that trade with China has dismantled domestic industries, resulting in job losses, shuttered factories, and the decline of once-thriving middle-class communities (Quah, 2026) (Quah, 2026). Consequently, the global economy is splintering into separate blocs, leaving small states to manage the price of fragmentation, which the IMF estimates could reduce global GDP by up to 7% (Quah, 2026).

Strategic Symbiosis: A Matter of National Survival

In this fractured landscape, the relationship between Cambodia and China is a strategic necessity. To understand why Cambodia seeks a close alignment with Beijing, one must view it through the lens of national security (Pu, 2026). For the Cambodian administration, China is not just a donor but can also be considered as a guarantor of stability. Cambodia has long faced a dual challenge: external pressure from Western powers for specific governance reforms as well as pressure from the big neighboring countries and internal pressures that threaten the stability of the state (Pu, 2026). When these threats converge, the resulting security crisis compels Cambodia to prioritize alignment with a partner that offers support without interfering in its internal governance.

China provides Cambodia with what Western donors often withhold: development support without political strings attached. Beijing is Cambodia's largest trading partner, its primary source of Foreign Direct Investment (FDI), and its top provider of official development assistance (Tung,

2025). This support is both tangible and transformative. Chinese firms have funded over 3,200 km of roads and eight major bridges (Tung, 2025). Strategically, projects like the Funan Techo Canal aim to link Phnom Penh directly to the Gulf of Thailand will enhance Cambodia national sovereignty (Tung, 2025; Pham, 2026).

From Beijing's perspective, Cambodia is a most reliable friend and a critical gateway to mainland Southeast Asia (Pham, 2026). Cambodia's support is vital for China's regional strategy, particularly within ASEAN, where it acts as a stable partner in a region where great power rivalry has intensified (Pham, 2026; Tung, 2025). This is not a relationship of passive submission, but one where a small state exercises big agency, leveraging great power competition to secure the resources needed to transform its economy (Tung, 2025).

Fairness to Cambodia: The Logic of Sovereignty and Development

It is essential to be fair to Cambodia's position. Often characterized by critics as over-dependent, Cambodia's strategy is actually a sophisticated attempt to maintain strategic autonomy in a difficult neighborhood. Cambodia's history is defined by its location between more powerful neighbors, Thailand and Vietnam (Hou, 2018). Today, territorial disputes over sites like the Preah Vihear temple continue to shape Cambodia's security outlook (Tung, 2025).

Lacking the material capabilities to counterbalance these neighbors alone, Cambodia views China as a vital regional counterweight (Tung, 2025). Furthermore, infrastructure in Cambodia remains at an embryonic stage, yet modernizing gradually, due to decades of civil war and social unrest (Hou, 2018). For Cambodia, infrastructure is the driving engine for the country's connectivity and competitiveness (Hou, 2018). China's willingness to invest billions in energy, transport, and manufacturing provides Cambodia with the capital it needs to reach its goal of becoming an upper-middle-income country by 2030 (Tung, 2025; Hou, 2018).

Fairness to China: Providing Global Public Goods

Moving forward, the greatest challenge to the international order is a massive deficit of trust. The United States is increasingly viewed as an unreliable partner because its extreme domestic polarization means that international commitments can be overturned in a future election via simple executive orders (Lake, 2026). This unreliability has broken a 75-year consensus on US leadership, forcing even close allies to look for alternatives to ensure their long-term security (Lake, 2026).

A neutral view also recognizes that China has provided the Global South with a much-needed alternative to the traditional Washington Consensus. China's development model offers a path to growth that respects national sovereignty and the principle of non-interference (Hou, 2018). While some parts of the world have turned inward, China has positioned itself as a provider of global public goods through the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) (Lake, 2026).

Strategically, China is also emerging as a global leader in the green transition, an "electrostate" that dominates the production of solar panels and electric vehicle technologies (Lake, 2026). The "Made in China 2025" policy is a cornerstone of this strategy, significantly enhancing carbon emission efficiency through "green technological innovation" and "industrial upgrading" (Wang & Shao, 2026). By subsidizing these technologies, China provides an unintended but vital technology-driven subsidy to the developing world, making the transition to a carbon-neutral economy more affordable for states like Cambodia (Ing & Rodrik, 2026).

Conclusion: Managed Pluralism or Competing Spheres?

The world order stands at a crossroads. We may be headed toward "managed pluralism," where great powers recognize their differences and negotiate common understandings to prevent conflict (Lake, 2026). Alternatively, we may see the formalization of "separate spheres of influence," where trust is localized within blocs and supply chains are weaponized (Lake, 2026).

For a small state like Cambodia, the path forward involves a delicate "pendulum" between different strategic tools (Pu, 2026). When external pressures from the West are low, Cambodia returns to a strategy of "multidimensional hedging," balancing ties between China and the U.S. to maximize its strategic autonomy (Pu, 2026). However, the "centrifugal" forces of 2026 mean that trust is no longer a given. Cambodia's objective remains pragmatism. As Prime Minister Hun Manet has noted, Cambodia's goal is to be a non-aligned nation that is friends with any country while navigating a world that has grown increasingly unpredictable and fractured (Tung, 2025).

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